national election study suggests that 42 per cent in this age group wanted Modi as prime minister, with just 16 per cent preferring Rahul. The BJP got twice as many votes as the Congress did amongst first-time voters—an estimated 36 per cent versus 17 per cent (see appendix 2). In a cynical India tiring of its politicians, Modi offered a priceless four-letter word to a young and restless India—HOPE.

Rahul was twenty years younger than Modi, blessed with the most enduring family surname in Indian politics. He was well intentioned but that is never enough for an India living by the '*Dil Maange More*' slogan. Through the campaign, he appeared to speak the language of an older India—of handouts, of entitlements, even vote banks. At times, you almost felt a reversal of roles—it was Modi who would harp on rapid development, it was Rahul who would focus on issues tending to spread fear and insecurity amongst the minorities.

While Modi spoke of the twenty-first century belonging to India, Rahul would often talk of the past—of the sacrifices, for example, which his family had made. He did not offer a vision for the future. Even his 'Bharat versus India' divide appeared to suggest a stagnant nation that lived in two separate universes. His listless, almost dull, campaign never had a chance against the vigorous energy that Modi exuded. Not surprisingly, it was among India's first-time voters that the Rahul–Modi gap was widest. The role models of a new India aren't dynasts but self-made achievers.

Of course, it wasn't ever going to be easy for Rahul. He had to bear the baggage of the ten years' rule of the United Progressive Alliance (UPA). The Sonia–Manmohan diarchy had promised much initially, but an uneasy ruling coalition was bound to implode eventually. A unique power-sharing arrangement between a bureaucrat prime minister and a status quo-ist Congress president rapidly degenerated into sloth, corruption and, above all else, untamed inflation. The Indian voter can be rather tolerant of corruption, but what they are notoriously unforgiving of is rising prices. In every election tracker we've done, price rise has always been the top concern for the electorate. Almost five years of slow growth and high inflation is a recipe for political suicide. In the end, it was 'the economy,